



WORLDWIDE ENGLISH COLLEGE · LONDON CAMPUS

The IEFC Pronunciation Handbook

Every pronunciation target in the International English Fluency Certificate, arranged by what a teacher is looking for.



IEFC Reference Library · First edition · 2026-08-22
180 targets · 114 classroom stages · 60 model scripts
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Ordered by what you are looking for

The curriculum teaches pronunciation level by level, and this book does not. A teacher reaching for a pronunciation handbook is rarely asking what comes next; they are asking where a particular difficulty is taught, and the answer is spread across six levels.

So the six parts are the six kinds of pronunciation difficulty. Inside each, the curriculum sequence is preserved, level by level, so the progression is still visible. Appendix B recovers the curriculum order for anyone planning a term rather than solving a problem.

What is in each entry

ELEMENT	WHAT IT IS
Target	The feature being taught, in the curriculum's own words.
Example	The worked example the lesson uses. Stressed syllables are capitalised where the curriculum capitalises them.
Guidance	What to tell a learner who cannot produce it — written for the classroom, not for a phonetics course.
Reference	Level and module, so the target can be traced to the lesson that teaches it in the Complete Curriculum.

WHAT THIS BOOK DOES NOT CONTAIN

No phonemic transcription: the curriculum does not use the International Phonetic Alphabet, and adding a transcription this programme does not teach would be a different book with a different syllabus behind it. No audio: the 60 model scripts in Appendix A have been written and none has been recorded. Nothing in these pages has been composed for this volume — every target, example, guidance note and script is read from the academic database that the Complete Curriculum is set from.

The six parts

PART	FOCUS	TARGETS	LEVELS
I	Individual sounds	15	I II III
II	Word stress	19	I II III V VI

PART	FOCUS	TARGETS	LEVELS
III	Sentence stress	46	I II III IV V VI
IV	Rhythm	15	I II IV V VI
V	Intonation	49	I II III IV V VI
VI	Connected speech	36	I II III IV V VI



Individual sounds

A single consonant or vowel a learner's first language does not use, or uses differently.
The hardest to hear and the quickest to fossilise.

15 TARGETS ACROSS 15 MODULES · I · II · III

Level I · Foundation Programme A1

/h/ at the start of a word

I.1

Hello. How are you?

Many languages drop this sound. Breathe out gently before the vowel — you should feel warm air on your hand held in front of your mouth. Without it, "Hello" becomes "Ello".

Module 1: Meeting People · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Greetings, Country Stress & Wh-Questions

/ð/ in there, this, that

I.2

There is a desk. This is my room.

Put the tip of your tongue lightly between your teeth and let your voice buzz. If it becomes /d/ ("dere") or /z/ ("zere"), your tongue is behind the teeth instead of between them.

Module 2: Everyday Objects & Places · Pronunciation Lab 2 — The /ð/ Sound, Short Forms & Sentence Rhythm

-s endings: /s/, /z/, /iz/

I.3

He works /s/. She leaves /z/. She watches /iz/.

After a voiceless sound (k, p, t, f) say /s/; after a voiced sound or vowel say /z/; after s, sh, ch, j, z add a whole syllable /iz/. Your ears already know this in your own language — the rule just makes it conscious.

Module 3: Family & Routines · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Third-Person Endings, Linking & Clock Times

Long /i:/ vs short /ɪ/

1.4

cheap / chip; sheet / shit; these / this

For /i:/ spread your lips as if smiling and hold the sound; for /ɪ/ relax the lips and keep it short. This pair causes more genuine embarrassment than any other vowel contrast in English.

Module 4: Food & Shopping · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Long and Short i, Prices & Polite Requests

English /r/ is not rolled or tapped

1.5

right; street; library

The tongue tip curls back slightly and touches nothing. Rolling or tapping it is the single most recognisable accent marker for many learners, and it is easy to change once noticed.

Module 5: Around Town · Pronunciation Lab 5 — The English r, Chunking Directions & Opening Politely

/æ/ vs /e/

1.6

bad / bed; man / men; sat / set

For /æ/ drop the jaw and open wide; for /e/ the mouth is much more closed. Many learners produce one sound for both, which makes bad and bed identical to a listener.

Module 6: Describing People & Things · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Short Vowels, Adjective Stress & Marking Contrast

-ed endings: /t/, /d/, /ɪd/

1.7

watched /t/; played /d/; visited /ɪd/

After a voiceless sound say /t/; after a voiced sound or vowel say /d/; only after t or d does -ed become a whole extra syllable /ɪd/. Adding a syllable everywhere — "watch-ed" — is the commonest A1 past-tense error.

Module 7: Past Experiences · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Past-Tense Endings, Weak Forms & Narrative Rhythm

can vs can't

1.8

I CAN swim. I CAN'T swim.

In British English can't has a long clear vowel and can is reduced to /kən/. The /t/ is often almost inaudible, so the VOWEL carries the meaning — listen for the vowel, not the t.

Module 8: Plans & Abilities · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Gonna, the can/can't Contrast & Negative Stress

The /3:/ vowel

I.9

hurts; word; nurse; work

Lips relaxed and neutral, tongue in the middle of the mouth, and the sound is LONG. Replacing it with a short vowel makes hurt and hut sound the same.

Module 9: Health & Feelings · Pronunciation Lab 9 — The /3:/ Vowel, Sympathetic Intonation & Modal Stress

The level's three ending rules together

I.10

works /s/, leaves /z/, watches /Iz/; walked /t/, played /d/, visited /Id/

Both rules follow the same logic: the sound BEFORE the ending decides. Getting these consistently right does more for intelligibility at A1 than any vowel.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level I Consolidation — Endings, Weak Forms & Rhythm

Level II · Elementary Programme A2

was and were in their weak forms

II.1

I was /wəz/ walking. They were /wə/ helping.

Unstressed, these almost vanish. They only take their strong form in short answers — "Yes, I WAS" — and knowing that is how you tell a past continuous from a present.

Module 1: Life Stories · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Used To, Weak Past Forms & Interrupted Actions

Final consonant clusters

II.3

asked /a:skt/; worked; next; helped

Three consonants can meet at the end of an English word. Dropping the last one turns asked into ask and loses the past tense entirely — a grammar error caused purely by pronunciation.

Module 3: Work & Study · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Final Clusters, D'you Reduction & Instruction Stress

The schwa /ə/ — the most common vowel in English

II.6

bigger /'bɪgə/; brighter; quieter; nearer

Every unstressed syllable tends towards this one neutral sound. Pronouncing the spelled vowel instead is what makes careful speech sound unnatural and, oddly, harder to follow.

Module 6: Homes & Neighbourhoods · Pronunciation Lab 6 — The Schwa, Weak Than & Comparative Stress

/v/ in every, never, have

II.7

every day; hardly ever; I've never

Top teeth touch the bottom lip and the voice buzzes. Replacing /v/ with /b/ or /f/ changes very to berry and is highly noticeable.

Module 7: Food, Health & Habits · Pronunciation Lab 7 — The /v/ Sound, Frequency Stress & Phrasal-Verb Stress

Level III · Intermediate Programme B1

can't versus can, again but faster

III.7

It CAN'T be — It can /kən/ be

At B1 speed this contrast reappears under pressure. As at A1, listen for the vowel length rather than the /t/, which is often unreleased entirely.

Module 7: Health, Body & Mind · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Deduction Modals, can/can't at Speed & Causal Pitch Steps

Word stress

Which syllable of a word carries the beat. English listeners recognise words by their stress pattern before they parse the sounds, so a misplaced stress can make a correctly pronounced word unrecognisable.

19 TARGETS ACROSS 19 MODULES · I · II · III · V · VI

Level I · Foundation Programme A1

Country names carry fixed stress

I.1

I'm from JaPAN. I'm from CHIna. I'm from BraZIL.

Stress the capitalised syllable and make it longer, not just louder. Country names are among the first words a learner says about themselves, so a misplaced stress here is heard constantly.

Module 1: Meeting People · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Greetings, Country Stress & Wh-Questions

Clock times keep the stress on the number

I.3

half past FIVE; SEven o'CLOCK

Times carry information, so the numbers are stressed. Flattening them makes a time hard to catch even when every sound is correct.

Module 3: Family & Routines · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Third-Person Endings, Linking & Clock Times

Prices: the numbers take the stress

I.4

four POUNDS FIFty; TWO fifty

Money is the information in a shopping exchange, so it is stressed and slightly slowed. Say it flat and the listener will ask again.

Module 4: Food & Shopping · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Long and Short i, Prices & Polite Requests

Adjective + noun: stress the noun

1.6

a small black BAG; a red NOTEbook

In an ordinary description the noun carries the main stress. Stressing the adjective instead signals contrast — "the BLACK bag, not the brown one" — so misplacing it changes the meaning.

Module 6: Describing People & Things · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Short Vowels, Adjective Stress & Marking Contrast

Level II · Elementary Programme A2

-teen vs -ty

11.2

thirTEEN vs THIRty; fifTEEN vs FIFTy

-teen numbers stress the second syllable and end with a clear /n/; -ty numbers stress the first and end in a short vowel. Confusing them is the commonest cause of a genuinely missed train.

Module 2: Travel & Transport · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Teen and Ty, Announcement Rhythm & Checking Back

Superlatives keep stress on the adjective

11.6

the most SENSible choice; the QUIEtest street

Most and -est are grammatical, not informational, so they stay unstressed. Stressing them sounds like an argument rather than a description.

Module 6: Homes & Neighbourhoods · Pronunciation Lab 6 — The Schwa, Weak Than & Comparative Stress

Contrastive stress in a change of mind

11.8

In THAT case, I'd rather have the reFUND.

Stressing that signals the reason has changed the decision. Without it the sentence sounds like the customer is repeating themselves.

Module 8: Shopping & Services · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Polite Firmness, Offer Reductions & Contrastive Stress

Dates and numbers under pressure

II.10

the FIFTEENTH of juLY; EIGHT months

As in Module 2, -teenth and -ty confusions matter most where the information does. Slow slightly on numbers — fluent speakers do.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level II Consolidation — Weak Forms, Numbers & Conversational Melody

Level III · Intermediate Programme B1

Slightly and only limit the criticism, and are stressed

III.3

It feels SLIGHTly optimistic. My ONLY concern is...

These limiters carry real meaning; they tell you how big the problem is. Missing their stress means missing the size of the objection.

Module 3: Work, Careers & Entrepreneurship · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Hedged Criticism, Compressed Softeners & Limiters

Percentages stress the number, not per cent

III.5

THIRTy-EIGHT per cent; about FOUR per cent

The unit is predictable; the number is the information. Speakers slow slightly on figures, and matching that slowing is what makes your own data delivery followable.

Module 5: Environment, Ethics & Global Citizenship · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Figures in Speech, Fact-versus-Judgement Pitch & Linking Numbers

Level V · Advanced Programme C1

Quantified hedges stress the quantity, not the hedge

V.4

within about FIVE per cent; out by about FORTy per cent

The hedge is grammatical; the number is the claim. Speakers who stress roughly or about instead sound evasive about figures they have actually measured.

Module 4: Complex Systems (Science, Economics, Policy) · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Quantified Hedging, Category Diagnosis & Audible Feedback Loops

Empty candour phrases are over-stressed

V.6

I've been COMPLETEly OPEN about this THROUGHout.

Heavy stress on every content word with no specific information is a reliable marker of a non-answer. Real answers distribute stress unevenly.

Module 6: Advanced Media & Discourse Analysis · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Reframe Detection, Correction Rhythm & Over-Stressed Emptiness

Level VI · English Mastery Programme C2

Mandative subjunctive: the bare verb, unstressed but present

VI.1

I'd recommend that the committee APPROVE... // It's essential that the staff HEAR this.

The subjunctive verb takes no -s and no auxiliary. In fast speech the absence is easy to miss, and mishearing it as an indicative flattens a recommendation into a description.

Module 1: Mastery Diagnostic & Executive Leadership · Pronunciation Lab 1 — The Subjunctive in Speech, Ownership Stress & Holding a Position

Fronted complements with inversion

VI.3

CENtral to my concern IS that a discount is hard to reVERSE.

Fronting places the evaluation first and delays the subject. The heavy stress on the fronted element is what makes the inversion sound deliberate rather than awkward.

Module 3: Global Business Strategy · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Three-Layer Rhythm, Falsifiability Stress & Fronted Complements

Operative modals are stressed when contrasted

VI.4

We intended MUST. MAY confers discretion.

These words are normally unstressed function words. In drafting discussion they become the content, and the stress shift signals that the argument is about the word itself.

Module 4: Public Policy · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Operative Modal Stress, Enumerated Options & Criterion Framing

Locating disagreement stresses the level

VI.5

My disagreement is not with the PREMise but with the SCOPE.

Naming premise, warrant, inference or scope, with stress on the chosen term, is the module's analytical instrument made audible.

Module 5: Law & Justice · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Opposed Operators, Warm Steelmanning & Locating Disagreement

Inverted conditionals stress the fronted auxiliary

VI.6

WERE this approach to work... // SHOULD it not work... // HAD they raised prices...

With if omitted, the auxiliary carries the conditional meaning and takes the stress. Unstressed, the clause is heard as a statement and the conditionality is lost.

Module 6: Innovation & Emerging Technologies · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Fronted Auxiliaries, Unapologetic Disclosure & Enumerated Conditions

The ladder rungs are stressed as the claim

VI.8

Your abstract says it DEMonstrates. Your data does NOT demonstrate that.

Reporting verbs are normally unstressed. When the verb IS the dispute, it takes full stress, and that shift is how a listener knows the argument is about calibration.

Module 8: Research & Scholarship · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Ladder Verb Stress, Academic Antithesis & Clean Acceptance

Even though concedes a fact; even if concedes a hypothesis

VI.9

EVEN THOUGH the forms permit it... // EVEN IF publication caused no harm...

The stress falls on the concessive phrase itself. Mishearing one for the other means mishearing whether the speaker accepts the premise — which reverses their position.

Module 9: Ethics & Responsible Leadership · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Concessive Contrast, However-Inversion & Naming the Cost

Sentence stress

Which words in an utterance are given weight. It carries meaning: the same sentence stressed differently is a different statement.

46 TARGETS ACROSS 46 MODULES · I · II · III · IV · V · VI

Level I · Foundation Programme A1

Content words carry the beat

1.2

There's a BED near the WINDOW.

Say only the capitalised words first, keeping the rhythm, then add the small words quietly between them. English rhythm is built on stressed words, not on syllable count.

Module 2: Everyday Objects & Places · Pronunciation Lab 2 — The /ð/ Sound, Short Forms & Sentence Rhythm

Correcting information moves the stress

1.6

It's not NEW — it's quite OLD.

English marks contrast by stress, not by word order. Learning to hear this is how you catch which part of a sentence is the point.

Module 6: Describing People & Things · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Short Vowels, Adjective Stress & Marking Contrast

Stress falls on can't, never on can

1.8

I can SWIM. — I CAN'T swim.

In the positive, the verb is stressed; in the negative, can't is. This stress difference is what a listener actually uses to tell them apart.

Module 8: Plans & Abilities · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Gonna, the can/can't Contrast & Negative Stress

should and shouldn't in advice

1.9

You should DRINK plenty of water. You SHOULDN'T go to work.

As with can, the positive stresses the main verb and the negative stresses the modal. This is how advice and prohibition are told apart at speed.

Module 9: Health & Feelings · Pronunciation Lab 9 — The /3:/ Vowel, Sympathetic Intonation & Modal Stress

Sustaining rhythm across a whole paragraph

I.10

CLASSES start at NINE and FINish at half past THREE.

Level I ends here: keeping stressed words on a steady beat while everything between them is compressed. This is the foundation every later level builds on.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level I Consolidation — Endings, Weak Forms & Rhythm

Level II · Elementary Programme A2

Instructions stress the new information

II.3

You START at half past EIGHT and FINish at FIVE.

In a list of duties the times and the verbs carry the meaning. Flat delivery makes an instruction sound optional.

Module 3: Work & Study · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Final Clusters, D'you Reduction & Instruction Stress

Concession stresses the contrast word

II.4

I see your POINT, BUT I find the stories WEAK.

The stress lands on but and on the criticism. This is the rhythm of English concession, and hearing it tells you a disagreement is coming before the words arrive.

Module 4: Likes, Dislikes & Opinions · Pronunciation Lab 4 — The Melody of Disagreement, Hedges & Concession

Present continuous for arrangements stresses the activity

II.5

I'm MEETing my BROTHer at eLEVen.

An arrangement stresses what and when. Compare a spontaneous decision — "I'll TEXT you" — where the stress falls on the new verb.

Module 5: Making Plans · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Future Reductions, Arrangement Stress & Suggesting

Frequency adverbs are stressed when they carry the answer

II.7

HARDly EVer. — SOMEtimes MORE.

In a short answer the frequency IS the information, so it takes full stress. Mid-sentence — "I sometimes walk" — it reduces again.

Module 7: Food, Health & Habits · Pronunciation Lab 7 — The /v/ Sound, Frequency Stress & Phrasal-Verb Stress

Level III · Intermediate Programme B1

Strong forms only in short answers and contrast

III.1

Yes, I HAVE. — I HAVEN'T done it since.

Auxiliaries take full stress only when carrying the answer or a negative. Learning both forms of the same word is what makes this grammar audible.

Module 1: Present Perfect & Life Experience · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Reduced Auxiliaries, Strong Forms & Experience Questions

The contrast pair takes the heaviest stress

III.2

FaMILiarity is not the same as reCALL.

When a speaker sets two ideas against each other, both take strong stress. That double stress is the audible marker of the main point of a section.

Module 2: Education & Learning · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Section Resets, Signposting Chunks & Contrast Stress

Concession stresses the thing conceded, then the turn

III.4

I don't dispute the AIR quality. My WORRY is WHO it affects.

The pattern is concede-then-turn. Both halves take strong stress, and the stress on the turn word is what tells you the disagreement is arriving.

Module 4: Opinions & Debate · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Concede-and-Turn, Connector Pitch & Formulaic Concessions

The swapped words take contrastive stress

III.6

SUGGESTS became PROVE. MAY BE LIKELY became CAUSES.

When a speaker contrasts two versions, both words are heavily stressed. This is the audible shape of the module's whole analytical point.

Module 6: Technology & Media · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Contrastive Stress, Headline Register & Vanishing Qualifiers

Deduction modals are stressed and carry certainty

III.7

That MUST raise your alertness. It CAN'T be the whole story.

Must and can't take strong stress because they are the claim. A flat delivery makes a confident deduction sound like a guess.

Module 7: Health, Body & Mind · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Deduction Modals, can/can't at Speed & Causal Pitch Steps

Repair stresses the pronoun taking responsibility

III.8

I should have exPLAINED. — No, I should have ASKED.

Stressing the pronoun is how each speaker claims the fault. That pronoun stress is the audible mechanism of a repair, and it is easy to miss.

Module 8: Travel & Culture · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Hinted Complaint, Minimisers & Pronoun Stress in Repair

Rules are stressed on the verb; reasons on the cause

III.9

DON'T GUESS a source. — BeCAUSE a wrong citation sends your reader SOMEwhere WRONG.

Instruction and justification have different rhythms. Recognising the switch tells you when the speaker has moved from what to why.

Module 9: Academic Foundations · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Rule-versus-Reason Stress, Academic Reduction & Conditional Shape

Panel disagreement keeps the concede-and-turn rhythm

III.10

I don't dispute the FIGure, BUT I suSPECT...

Module 4's pattern, now among three speakers. Tracking who concedes what is how you follow a panel without decoding every word.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level III Consolidation — Auxiliaries, Hedges & Panel Rhythm

Level IV · Upper Intermediate Programme B2

Paired abstractions take equal contrastive stress

IV.1

REASonable and RIGHT aren't the same thing.

When two near-synonyms are set against each other, both are stressed. This is the audible signature of the analytical move this level teaches.

Module 1: Advanced Present & Past Systems · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Reduced had, Hindsight Contour & Paired Abstractions

Diagnostic moves stress the corrected term

IV.2

That's a TOPic, not a THesis.

The two nouns take equal heavy stress. In tutorial speech this contrast pattern is the diagnosis, and hearing it is how you know which word to fix.

Module 2: Academic Writing I · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Diagnostic Contrast, Socratic Rise & Clustered Hedges

Observation and evaluation are stressed differently

IV.3

Both went out AFTER the DEADline. // I'm NOT asSUMing I know WHY.

The factual observation carries even stress; the disclaimer of judgement stresses the negation. Keeping these apart is what makes feedback land as fair.

Module 3: The World of Work · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Observation-versus-Evaluation Stress, Consent Rise & Reflective Reduction

Weak and strong take heavy contrastive stress

IV.4

The WEAK version... // The STRONG version...

This module's whole structure is one contrast pair, repeated. Following the stress is following the argument.

Module 4: Arguing a Position · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Voicing Another Position, Weak-versus-Strong Stress & Conditional Chunking

Procedural and substantive are the organising contrast

IV.5

The FIRST was proCEDural... // The SECond objection was subSTANtive.

The whole explanation hangs on this pair. Speakers stress such organising terms heavily precisely so listeners can hold the structure.

Module 5: Science, Technology & Ethics · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Compressed Passives, Organising Contrasts & Concede-then-Conclude

Both and different carry the resolution

IV.6

BOTH, and that's the unCOMfortable answer. They measure DIFFerent things.

When a speaker refuses a false choice, the stress falls on both and on the distinguishing word. That pattern is the audible shape of a methodological answer.

Module 6: Global Issues · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Refusing a False Choice, Subordinated Figures & Compressed Agreement

Knew versus should have known is the whole distinction

IV.7

Did they say the minister KNEW, or that she SHOULD HAVE known?

One stressed word separates a fact from an inference. This module's analytical objective is audible in that single contrast.

Module 7: Media Literacy & Critical Reading · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Fact-versus-Inference Stress, Unhedged Register & Reporting Frames

A traded concession stresses the condition

IV.8

IF you'll extend the term to THREE years, YES.

The stress on if and on the condition marks this as an exchange, not a gift. Missing it makes a negotiator sound as though they simply conceded.

Module 8: Meetings & Negotiation · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Conditional Stress, Probe-versus-Offer Contours & Numeric Clarity

Coverage versus organisation is the diagnosis

IV.9

COVerge isn't the problem. // OrganiSAtion is.

Two abstract nouns in contrast, the second stressed and standing alone. This is how academic supervision delivers a structural diagnosis in six words.

Module 9: Academic Writing II · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Abstract-Noun Contrast, Instruction Contour & Homophone Disambiguation

Summing up stresses the two verdicts

IV.10

The substantive case is unPROVEN and the procedural condition is unMET.

A chair's summary stresses each verdict word. That is how a decision is signalled before it is stated — and how you know a meeting is about to end.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level IV Consolidation — Meeting Pace, Verdict Stress & Closure

Level V · Advanced Programme C1

Contrastive pairs carry the real message

V.1

The PAPER is GOOD. The TIMING is DREADful.

Two short parallel sentences with heavy stress on the evaluations. The structure does the work; the speaker never says the proposal will fail.

Module 1: Nuance & Idiom · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Implicature by Intonation, Evaluative Contrast & Deniable Advice

Modal contrast carries the whole answer

V.2

I CAN'T fully exclude it. // What I CAN show is...

Stress on can't and can in successive clauses marks the exact boundary of the claim. This is the audible form of scholarly precision.

Module 2: Academic Writing III · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Concede-then-Defend, Modal Boundary Stress & Protected References

Ownership stresses the first-person pronoun

V.3

This was MY recommendation. // I'm NOT going to hide behind them.

Stressing I and my is how English marks accountability. Unstressed, the same sentence reads as procedural information rather than as taking responsibility.

Module 3: Leadership & Persuasion · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Ownership Stress, Slowed Concession & Three-Beat Framing

Diagnosis stresses the category, not the symptom

V.4

It's NOT a caliBRAtion problem. // You can't TUNE your way out of a MISSing relationship.

The distinction between kinds of error is the whole analysis. Stress marks which category is being excluded.

Module 4: Complex Systems (Science, Economics, Policy) · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Quantified Hedging, Category Diagnosis & Audible Feedback Loops

Reinterpretation stresses the corrected reading

V.5

I read the pause as THINKing. — It WAS thinking. About how to disaGREE.

Repeating the other speaker's word with stress, then extending it, is how English performs a correction that does not contradict.

Module 5: Cross-Cultural Communication · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Pause as Meaning, Falling Evaluations & Non-Contradictory Correction

A reframe stresses a different noun from the question

V.6

Will you reSIGN? — What matters is that the report is PUBLished.

The substituted noun carries the stress. Hearing which noun was swapped is the fastest way to detect a reframe in real time.

Module 6: Advanced Media & Discourse Analysis · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Reframe Detection, Correction Rhythm & Over-Stressed Emptiness

Declining to speculate stresses the boundary

V.7

That's OUTSIDE what my DATA can supPORT.

Stressing outside and data marks this as a principled limit rather than an evasion. Said flatly, the same words sound like avoidance.

Module 7: Research & Presentation · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Three-Beat Structure, The Clean Stop & Principled Limits

Refusal to speculate stresses the action, not the denial

V.8

I'm not going to SPECulate about a document I HAVEN'T SEEN. // I've told you what I'll DO about it.

Ending on the commitment rather than the refusal is what stops a non-answer sounding evasive.

Module 8: Professional Advocacy · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Four-Part Crisis Rhythm, Tempo Under Interruption & Ending on Action

Verbal style restores a regular beat

V.9

When we introDUCED the POLicy, FEWer YOUNG people apPLIED.

Verbs and concrete nouns produce evenly spaced stresses. This is what readers experience as clarity.

Module 9: Style & Voice · Pronunciation Lab 9 — The Rhythm of Nominalisation, Verbal Beat & The Diagnostic Question

The distinction that resolves the meeting

V.10

I'm not opPOSED. I'm opposed to approving it on THIS arithmetic.

Stress on this narrows the objection from the proposal to its basis, which is what makes a compromise possible. One stressed word changes the outcome of the meeting.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level V Consolidation — Understatement, Narrowing Stress & Board Closure

Level VI · English Mastery Programme C2

Accountability stresses the possessive and the modal

VI.1

The decision was still MINE and I'D OWN the consequence.

Unqualified ownership is marked by stress on mine and would. This is the executive register the whole level opens with.

Module 1: Mastery Diagnostic & Executive Leadership · Pronunciation Lab 1 — The Subjunctive in Speech, Ownership Stress & Holding a Position

Comparatives carry the concession's size

VI.2

It would be conSIDerably more COMfortable.

In diplomatic register the degree adverb is the message. Considerably versus somewhat is the difference between agreement and a further round of talks.

Module 2: Diplomacy & International Relations · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Litotes Delivery, Degree Adverbs & Impersonal Formulas

Falsifiability stresses the condition

VI.3

What would have to be TRUE for that inference to be WRONG?

The stress on true and wrong marks this as a test rather than a rhetorical challenge. It is the module's central technique, and it is a question that expects an answer.

Module 3: Global Business Strategy · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Three-Layer Rhythm, Falsifiability Stress & Fronted Complements

Criterion framing stresses the criterion

VI.4

AsSESSed against ENFORCEability, the second is WEAKest.

Naming the criterion before the verdict is the module's discipline, and stressing it is how a listener knows a new criterion has been introduced.

Module 4: Public Policy · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Operative Modal Stress, Enumerated Options & Criterion Framing

The two operators are stressed against each other

VI.5

SUBject to section nine means section NINE wins. NOTwithSTANDIng section nine means YOUR clause wins.

Two long phrases distinguished by heavy stress on the operator and on the winner. This parallel structure is how the distinction is taught and how it is remembered.

Module 5: Law & Justice · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Opposed Operators, Warm Steelmanning & Locating Disagreement

Partial concession stresses both halves

VI.7

On REACHIng customers, YES. On idENtifying the fault and ACTIng, NO.

Parallel structure with opposed answers. Both stressed equally, this is a genuine partial concession; stressing only one half is heard as spin.

Module 7: Media & Public Communication · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Premise Correction Speed, Partial Concession & The Single Tricolon

The parallel judgement stresses both evaluations

VI.8

They FEEL like better WRITing and they ARE worse SCHOLArship.

Antithesis in academic speech, with heavy stress on both halves. One sentence carries the module's entire ethic.

Module 8: Research & Scholarship · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Ladder Verb Stress, Academic Antithesis & Clean Acceptance

Naming the cost stresses who bears it

VI.9

Some PARTicipants will feel deCEIVED even though nothing imPROPER occurred.

Stating a position's cost, with stress on who pays it, is the module's ethical discipline. The chair's response marks it as the valuable move.

Module 9: Ethics & Responsible Leadership · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Concessive Contrast, However-Inversion & Naming the Cost

Defending a premise stresses the premise, not the conclusion

VI.10

The PREMise is that near-term harm is already LOCKED IN.

The examiner asked for the premise; the answer must stress it. Answering the question actually asked, audibly, is the whole skill of an oral defence.

Module 10: Capstone — Global Challenges & Mastery Examination · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Programme Consolidation
— Premise Stress, The Honest Limit & Knowing When to Stop

Rhythm

English is stress-timed — the beats fall at roughly even intervals and the unstressed syllables compress to fit. Learners from syllable-timed languages have to unlearn evenness.

15 TARGETS ACROSS 15 MODULES · I · II · IV · V · VI

Level I · Foundation Programme A1

One instruction, one rhythmic group

I.5

Go STRAIGHT ON // then turn RIGHT // into KING Street.

Directions are chunked with a small pause between each step. Delivered as one long line they cannot be followed even when every word is clear.

Module 5: Around Town · Pronunciation Lab 5 — The English r, Chunking Directions & Opening Politely

Time phrases open the sentence and take their own group

I.7

On SATurday // I visited my GRANDmother.

Fronted time phrases form a separate rhythmic chunk with a small pause. This is how a listener knows immediately that the story has moved to a new day.

Module 7: Past Experiences · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Past-Tense Endings, Weak Forms & Narrative Rhythm

Level II · Elementary Programme A2

Storytelling slows before the point

II.9

And THEN — you won't beLIEVE this — the LIGHTS came back ON.

Speakers slow down and often pause before a punchline. That slowing is a signal to the listener that the important part is arriving; recognising it is a listening skill in itself.

Module 9: Telling Stories · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Narrative Pace, Discourse Markers & Backgrounding

Level IV · Upper Intermediate Programme B 2

Conditional challenges chunk into three

IV.4

If you CAN'T state your opponent's case // BETter than THEY can, // you don't underSTAND it yet.

Long conditional sentences break into rhythmic groups at the clause boundaries. Hearing those boundaries is what makes complex sentences followable in real time.

Module 4: Arguing a Position · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Voicing Another Position, Weak-versus-Strong Stress & Conditional Chunking

Level V · Advanced Programme C 1

Structure announced in three beats

V.3

the deCiSion first, // then the REAsoning, // then take QUESTions.

Announcing the shape of a difficult message before delivering it is a leadership convention, and the three-beat rhythm makes it memorable under stress.

Module 3: Leadership & Persuasion · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Ownership Stress, Slowed Concession & Three-Beat Framing

Pause length is meaning, not hesitation

V.5

...the schedule was ambitious. [4 second pause] ...Yes, we can try.

In several conversational cultures a long pause before agreement IS the disagreement. English speakers typically fill pauses at around one second and so hear silence as absence rather than as content.

Module 5: Cross-Cultural Communication · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Pause as Meaning, Falling Evaluations & Non-Contradictory Correction

Three announced steps take three equal beats

V.7

the effect is REAL, // it's SMALLer than reported, // and it's condITional.

Equal rhythmic weight on each step makes a three-part structure memorable to an audience without slides. Uneven delivery loses the third item.

Module 7: Research & Presentation · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Three-Beat Structure, The Clean Stop & Principled Limits

The four-part statement takes four equal blocks

V.8

what we KNOW // what we do NOT yet know // what we are DOing // when you'll HEAR from us

Equal rhythmic weight signals a structure the audience can hold. The second block is the one organisations omit, and delivering it at full weight is what builds credibility.

Module 8: Professional Advocacy · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Four-Part Crisis Rhythm, Tempo Under Interruption & Ending on Action

Nominalised prose has fewer stresses per second

V.9

the imPLEMENTation of the POLicy resulted in a reDUCTION...

Abstract nouns bury stress in long unstressed runs. The flatness is why nominalised prose is tiring to hear, and hearing that flatness is how a writer learns to detect it in their own drafts.

Module 9: Style & Voice · Pronunciation Lab 9 — The Rhythm of Nominalisation, Verbal Beat & The Diagnostic Question

The chair's resolution takes three beats

V.10

approve MARKet one, // deFER market two, // reVISit in the AUtumn.

The same three-beat closure heard at Levels III and IV, now carrying a compromise rather than a decision. It is the standard shape of senior resolution in English.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level V Consolidation — Understatement, Narrowing Stress & Board Closure

Level VI · English Mastery Programme C2

The three layers take three distinct rhythmic blocks

VI.3

THREE FACTS... // My INference is... // My recommenDation is...

Separating the layers rhythmically is what allows a board to challenge one without rejecting the others. Collapsing them is the characteristic failure of the genre.

Module 3: Global Business Strategy · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Three-Layer Rhythm, Falsifiability Stress & Fronted Complements

Enumerated options take equal weight

VI.4

MUST with funding, // MAY with published criteria, // or SHALL within a stated period.

Three options in equal rhythmic blocks. Uneven delivery signals a preference the speaker may not intend to reveal.

Module 4: Public Policy · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Operative Modal Stress, Enumerated Options & Criterion Framing

Enumerated conditions land in equal blocks

VI.6

TWO things: // reagent supply stable for eighteen MONTHS, // and ethics approval by MARCH.

Announcing the count then delivering equal blocks lets a panel record both without asking for repetition.

Module 6: Innovation & Emerging Technologies · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Fronted Auxiliaries, Unapologetic Disclosure & Enumerated Conditions

The tricolon earns its place by being the only one

VI.7

THREE things: verified contact DETails, // a public REGister, // and an external AUDit.

One rhetorical device in a whole interview lands. Used repeatedly it reads as evasion, which is the module's governing rule.

Module 7: Media & Public Communication · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Premise Correction Speed, Partial Concession & The Single Tricolon

The clean short answer as the strongest answer

VI.10

You could simply have said YES. — I COULD. It WOULDn't have been TRUE.

Six words, three stresses, complete stop. After six levels of learning to elaborate, the capstone tests whether a speaker knows when not to.

Module 10: Capstone — Global Challenges & Mastery Examination · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Programme Consolidation — Premise Stress, The Honest Limit & Knowing When to Stop

Intonation

The melody of the utterance: where the pitch rises, falls, and where it does both. It carries attitude, and getting it wrong sounds like rudeness rather than error.

49 TARGETS ACROSS 49 MODULES · I · II · III · IV · V · VI

Level I · Foundation Programme A1

Wh-questions fall at the end

I.1

Where are you FROM? (voice goes down)

A rising voice on a Wh-question sounds uncertain or surprised. Let your pitch drop on the last stressed word — this is what makes a question sound friendly rather than doubtful.

Module 1: Meeting People · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Greetings, Country Stress & Wh-Questions

Polite requests rise at the end

I.4

Can I have some bread, please? (voice goes up)

A falling voice on a request sounds like an instruction. The rise is what makes it polite — in English, politeness is carried by melody at least as much as by the word please.

Module 4: Food & Shopping · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Long and Short i, Prices & Polite Requests

Excuse me rises to open politely

I.5

exCUSE me (voice up), how do I GET to the library? (voice down)

The opening rise gets attention politely; the Wh-question then falls. Getting these the wrong way round sounds either aggressive or uncertain.

Module 5: Around Town · Pronunciation Lab 5 — The English r, Chunking Directions & Opening Politely

Sympathy falls gently and slows

I.9

Oh DEAR. I'm SORry to hear that. (falling, slower)

A rise here sounds like surprise or disbelief. Warmth in English is carried by a gentle fall and a slower pace, not by extra words.

Module 9: Health & Feelings · Pronunciation Lab 9 — The /3:/ Vowel, Sympathetic Intonation & Modal Stress

Level II • Elementary Programme A2

An interrupted action drops, the interruption rises then falls

11.1

I was WALKing home // when I SAW an ACCident.

The two clauses form two groups. The junction at when is where the listener understands that one action cut across another.

Module 1: Life Stories · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Used To, Weak Past Forms & Interrupted Actions

Checking back rises steeply

11.2

Platform THIRty? (sharp rise)

A steep rise signals "I am not sure I heard that correctly" and invites repetition. It is a repair strategy, and using it is a skill, not a failure.

Module 2: Travel & Transport · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Teen and Ty, Announcement Rhythm & Checking Back

Disagreement starts high and falls gently

11.4

HMM. I'm not REALly keen on it, to be HONest.

English softens disagreement with melody first. A flat "I don't like it" is heard as blunt even when the words are mild — the tune is doing the politeness.

Module 4: Likes, Dislikes & Opinions · Pronunciation Lab 4 — The Melody of Disagreement, Hedges & Concession

Suggestions rise; corrections fall

11.5

Shall we meet at TWELVE? (up) — Actually, let's make it ONE. (down)

A rising suggestion invites agreement; a falling correction takes it back gently. This pair is the whole grammar of negotiating a plan.

Module 5: Making Plans · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Future Reductions, Arrangement Stress & Suggesting

Firm but polite: falling, steady, unhurried

11.8

I'd PREfer a replacement, if you HAVE the same model.

Rising pitch here sounds uncertain and invites refusal; a sharp fall sounds aggressive. A steady, unhurried fall is the sound of a complaint that gets resolved.

Module 8: Shopping & Services · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Polite Firmness, Offer Reductions & Contrastive Stress

Background information drops in pitch

II.9

We were having dinner — my whole FAMily, about TEN of us — and...

Parenthetical background is said lower and faster, then the main line resumes at normal pitch. This layering is how an English speaker signals what is scene-setting and what is plot.

Module 9: Telling Stories · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Narrative Pace, Discourse Markers & Backgrounding

Sustaining interview rhythm across turns

II.10

Question rises, answer falls, aside drops lower.

The whole level's melody in one text: rising questions, falling answers, and lowered parenthetical asides. Following those contours is how you follow a conversation you cannot fully decode word by word.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level II Consolidation — Weak Forms, Numbers & Conversational Melody

Level III · Intermediate Programme B1

Ever-questions rise; experience answers fall

III.1

Have you EVER taught adults? (rise) — I TAUGHT a class last summer. (fall)

The rise invites a yes/no; the falling answer signals a completed anecdote is starting. Following that shift is how you know an answer is going to be a story.

Module 1: Present Perfect & Life Experience · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Reduced Auxiliaries, Strong Forms & Experience Questions

A new section resets to a higher pitch

III.2

MOVING ON to re-reading. // WHICH BRINGS ME to my third point.

Lecturers restart high at each new section. That reset is the clearest structural signal in academic listening, and note-takers who hear it never lose their place.

Module 2: Education & Learning · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Section Resets, Signposting Chunks & Contrast Stress

Hedged criticism falls slowly and stays warm

III.3

I SUPPOSE my only real conCERN is the PRICing.

The slow fall and the hedges together signal help rather than attack. Delivered fast and flat, the identical words land as a dismissal.

Module 3: Work, Careers & Entrepreneurship · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Hedged Criticism, Compressed Softeners & Limiters

But and however reset the pitch upward

III.4

...for exactly those groups. // BUT exemptions are a DESIGN problem.

A raised pitch on the connector marks a change of direction. In debate this is the single most useful contour to recognise.

Module 4: Opinions & Debate · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Concede-and-Turn, Connector Pitch & Formulaic Concessions

Facts are level; interpretations dip and slow

III.5

...fell by about four per cent. // NOW, in OUR VIEW, the fall is exPLAINED by...

English marks a shift from reporting to interpreting with a pitch and pace change. Hearing it is the listening half of the module's critical-thinking objective.

Module 5: Environment, Ethics & Global Citizenship · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Figures in Speech, Fact-versus-Judgement Pitch & Linking Numbers

Headline delivery is flat, fast and assertive

III.6

SCIENtists PROVE: LACK of SLEEP CAUSES dePRESSion.

Headline register removes hedges and levels the pitch. Recognising that flat assertive contour is itself a critical-reading skill.

Module 6: Technology & Media · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Contrastive Stress, Headline Register & Vanishing Qualifiers

Cause-and-effect chains step down in pitch

III.7

FOUR hours left. // Then THREE. // And that CALculation must RAISE your alertness.

Each step in a causal chain sits slightly lower than the last, then resets at the conclusion. Following the steps is how you follow the reasoning.

Module 7: Health, Body & Mind · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Deduction Modals, can/can't at Speed & Causal Pitch Steps

Indirect complaint stays light and rises slightly

III.8

It's JUST that we tend to eat toGETHer at SEVen...

The upward, light delivery is what makes it a hint rather than an accusation. A falling delivery of identical words would be a formal complaint.

Module 8: Travel & Culture · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Hinted Complaint, Minimisers & Pronoun Stress in Repair

Conditional consequences fall on the outcome

III.9

If you genuinely CAN'T trace it, // either FIND a source // or STATE it as your own.

The condition rises, the options fall. Hearing that shape lets you count the options before you have decoded them.

Module 9: Academic Foundations · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Rule-versus-Reason Stress, Academic Reduction & Conditional Shape

Recommendations end on a fall, conditions on a rise

III.10

KEEP the projects, HALVE the reading. // If we DON'T, we'll LOSE the benefit.

A firm falling recommendation followed by a rising-then-falling conditional warning. This is the shape of professional advice, and it recurs throughout Levels IV to VI.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level III Consolidation — Auxiliaries, Hedges & Panel Rhythm

Level IV · Upper Intermediate Programme B2

Hindsight falls slowly and lengthens the key word

IV.1

I should have asked ONE question in week ONE.

Regret is marked by slowing and lengthening rather than by extra words. The contour itself communicates that this is a judgement on the past, not a report of it.

Module 1: Advanced Present & Past Systems · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Reduced had, Hindsight Contour & Paired Abstractions

Socratic questions rise and hang

IV.2

Increases it for WHOM? // And measured HOW?

A tutor's questions rise and stop, leaving space. That hanging contour is an invitation to answer, not a rhetorical flourish — responding to it is a seminar skill.

Module 2: Academic Writing I · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Diagnostic Contrast, Socratic Rise & Clustered Hedges

Checking consent rises and pauses

IV.3

Is NOW all right? (rise, then wait)

Opening a difficult conversation with a genuine rising question, then actually pausing, is a professional norm. A flat delivery makes it a formality rather than a choice.

Module 3: The World of Work · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Observation-versus-Evaluation Stress, Consent Rise & Reflective Reduction

Voicing another position drops in pitch and flattens

IV.4

The weak version is: MANagers just want conTROL.

Speakers lower and flatten their voice when quoting a view they do not hold. That shift is how a listener knows this is a reconstruction, not the speaker's claim.

Module 4: Arguing a Position · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Voicing Another Position, Weak-versus-Strong Stress & Conditional Chunking

Concession before a firm conclusion rises then falls hard

IV.5

It's conTESTed, and reasonable people land DIFFerently. // BUT it CAN'T be resolved by better PAPerwork.

The rise on the concession followed by a hard fall on the conclusion is the shape of a decision that has already been taken.

Module 5: Science, Technology & Ethics · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Compressed Passives, Organising Contrasts & Concede-then-Conclude

Figures inside argument are said faster and lower

IV.6

...has fallen by A THIRD. // It's right ON THAT MEASure.

When a number is not the point, it is subordinated in pitch. Recognising that tells you the speaker is about to challenge the framing rather than the figure.

Module 6: Global Issues · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Refusing a False Choice, Subordinated Figures & Compressed Agreement

Editorial challenge falls hard and does not soften

IV.7

Those AREN'T the same CLAIM. // And the second one ISN'T EVidence.

Unlike the hedged criticism of Level III Module 3, this register is deliberately unhedged. Recognising when English drops its softeners is itself information about the stakes.

Module 7: Media Literacy & Critical Reading · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Fact-versus-Inference Stress, Unhedged Register & Reporting Frames

Probing questions fall, offers rise

IV.8

What's DRIVING your ceiling? (fall) // Would you do EIGHT from APRIL? (rise)

Diagnostic questions fall because they demand information; offers rise because they invite acceptance. The two contours do different work at the table.

Module 8: Meetings & Negotiation · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Conditional Stress, Probe-versus-Offer Contours & Numeric Clarity

Instructions with a following rule fall then level

IV.9

THEN that's your section HEADIng, // and every source goes underNEATH it.

The instruction falls; the elaboration levels off. Hearing the drop tells you the actionable part has already been said.

Module 9: Academic Writing II · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Abstract-Noun Contrast, Instruction Contour & Homophone Disambiguation

The decision falls flat and final

IV.10

THEN that's the recommenDAtion. // Pilot next year, deCISion the year after.

No rise, no hedge. The flat final fall is the sound of a matter being closed, and it is the same contour used from here to Level VI.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level IV Consolidation — Meeting Pace, Verdict Stress & Closure

Level V · Advanced Programme C1

A very thorough hearing said with a level tone means no

V.1

They'll CERTainly give it a very THORough hearing. (level, unenthusiastic)

Enthusiasm would rise and vary; a level contour on positive words is heard by native listeners as polite refusal. This is the single most important C1 listening skill.

Module 1: Nuance & Idiom · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Implicature by Intonation, Evaluative Contrast & Deniable Advice

Concession falls, defence rises again immediately

V.2

That's the STRONGest objection, and I CAN'T fully exclude it. // What I CAN show is...

The fall concedes; the immediate re-rise on what I CAN show is the defence. Delivered without that re-rise, the concession sounds like collapse.

Module 2: Academic Writing III · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Concede-then-Defend, Modal Boundary Stress & Protected References

Acknowledging a hostile point falls and slows

V.3

That's a FAIR point // and it's PARTly TRUE.

Slowing down while conceding signals it is genuine. Speeding through a concession is heard, correctly, as getting past it.

Module 3: Leadership & Persuasion · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Ownership Stress, Slowed Concession & Three-Beat Framing

Chained causation steps down then resets

V.4

Higher PRICes reduced DEMAND, // which reduced SUPply, // which RAISED prices aGAIN.

Each link drops slightly; the return to the starting term rises. That contour is how a speaker makes a loop audible as a loop.

Module 4: Complex Systems (Science, Economics, Policy) · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Quantified Hedging, Category Diagnosis & Audible Feedback Loops

Ambitious said with a slight fall is a refusal

V.5

The schedule is amBITious. (falling, unhurried)

A positive-sounding evaluation with a falling, flat contour functions as an objection. This is the same mechanism as Module 1's thorough hearing, in a different cultural register.

Module 5: Cross-Cultural Communication · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Pause as Meaning, Falling Evaluations & Non-Contradictory Correction

Premise correction is delivered flat and fast, then slows

V.6

I was warned ELEVen months ago. // The DATE matters, and I'll come to WHY.

The correction itself is quick and unemphatic; the significance is delivered slowly. That two-part rhythm is what makes a correction sound like precision rather than defensiveness.

Module 6: Advanced Media & Discourse Analysis · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Reframe Detection, Correction Rhythm & Over-Stressed Emptiness

The clean stop falls and does not trail

V.7

Without it, we see NOTHing. // Next QUESTion.

Nervous speakers let their pitch trail upward and keep talking. The decisive fall followed by silence is what makes an answer sound complete.

Module 7: Research & Presentation · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Three-Beat Structure, The Clean Stop & Principled Limits

Steady pace under interruption

V.8

Maintain unchanged tempo when cut across; do not accelerate.

Accelerating signals panic; stopping concedes the floor. Holding tempo is a trained physical skill and is the core of this module's pronunciation work.

Module 8: Professional Advocacy · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Four-Part Crisis Rhythm, Tempo Under Interruption & Ending on Action

The diagnostic question is delivered slowly and falls

V.9

WHO did WHAT to WHOM?

Three stresses, evenly weighted, ending on a fall. Delivered as a real question rather than a rhetorical one, it is the module's whole method in four words.

Module 9: Style & Voice · Pronunciation Lab 9 — The Rhythm of Nominalisation, Verbal Beat & The Diagnostic Question

Understatement as objection, at senior register

V.10

That would be unusually FAST. (level, unhurried)

Level V closes where it opened: a positive-sounding evaluation delivered level is a refusal. At board level almost all disagreement arrives this way.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level V Consolidation — Understatement, Narrowing Stress & Board Closure

Level VI · English Mastery Programme C2

Acknowledging criticism without conceding it

VI.1

SOME would, and I've HEARD it. // My asSESSment is that it's the amBIGuity.

The acknowledgement rises; the counter-assessment falls. Neither dismisses nor accepts — this contour is how senior speakers hold a position under challenge.

Module 1: Mastery Diagnostic & Executive Leadership · Pronunciation Lab 1 — The Subjunctive in Speech, Ownership Stress & Holding a Position

Litotes is delivered level and unhurried

VI.2

It would NOT be unHELPful to know which part.

Double negation said with any emphasis becomes sarcasm. Level, slow delivery is what makes it read as courteous precision — the whole point of the form.

Module 2: Diplomacy & International Relations · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Litotes Delivery, Degree Adverbs & Impersonal Formulas

The steelman is delivered with genuine warmth

VI.5

The BEST case for the defendant is that the notice period was amBIGuous...

A steelman said flatly sounds like a formality. Delivering it as though you believe it is what makes the subsequent critique credible.

Module 5: Law & Justice · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Opposed Operators, Warm Steelmanning & Locating Disagreement

Honest risk disclosure is level and unapologetic

VI.6

The reAGent supply. There is ONE manufacturer.

Hedging or trailing off signals the speaker is uncomfortable. Flat, factual delivery is what makes disclosed risk read as competence rather than weakness.

Module 6: Innovation & Emerging Technologies · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Fronted Auxiliaries, Unapologetic Disclosure & Enumerated Conditions

Premise correction is quick, level and then moves on

VI.7

Let me correct the PREMise. We've known for eLEVen months.

Speed and levelness signal precision. Slowing down or emphasising heavily makes the same correction sound defensive, which invites the interviewer to press.

Module 7: Media & Public Communication · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Premise Correction Speed, Partial Concession & The Single Tricolon

Accepting correction falls cleanly without excess apology

VI.8

You're RIGHT. The correct verb is 'is consistent WITH'.

A short fall and immediate move to the fix. Extended apology in scholarly exchange reads as defensiveness; the clean acceptance is the professional norm.

Module 8: Research & Scholarship · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Ladder Verb Stress, Academic Antithesis & Clean Acceptance

However-inversion rises through the concession, falls on the claim

VI.9

HowEVER strong the research case, // I don't think the obligation YIELDS to it.

The fronted concession rises and holds; the main clause falls hard. That contour is what makes a concession sound like strength rather than retreat.

Module 9: Ethics & Responsible Leadership · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Concessive Contrast, However-Inversion & Naming the Cost

The honest non-answer falls and does not apologise

VI.10

That's OUTside what my evidence COVers. // I'd want to TEST it.

No rise, no trailing. The programme has taught this contour since Level V Module 7; here it appears under maximum pressure, which is the point.

Module 10: Capstone — Global Challenges & Mastery Examination · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Programme Consolidation — Premise Stress, The Honest Limit & Knowing When to Stop

Connected speech

What happens to words when they meet: linking, elision, assimilation, weak forms. The single largest cause of "I can read it but I cannot hear it".

36 TARGETS ACROSS 36 MODULES · I · II · III · IV · V · VI

Level I · Foundation Programme A1

There is -> there's; there are -> there're

1.2

There's a bed. There're two chairs.

Fluent speakers rarely say the full form. Learn to HEAR the short form even if you say the long one; this is why listening feels fast.

Module 2: Everyday Objects & Places · Pronunciation Lab 2 — The /ð/ Sound, Short Forms & Sentence Rhythm

Linking a final consonant to a following vowel

1.3

gets up -> "get-sup"; walks_ to school

English does not put a gap between words. Joining them is not sloppy speech; it is correct speech, and expecting gaps is why fluent English sounds too fast.

Module 3: Family & Routines · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Third-Person Endings, Linking & Clock Times

Weak was and were

1.7

I was /wəz/ tired. They were /wə/ late.

In natural speech these are almost never stressed. Learners who expect the strong form miss them entirely, and then miss that the sentence was in the past.

Module 7: Past Experiences · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Past-Tense Endings, Weak Forms & Narrative Rhythm

going to -> /'gənə/ before a verb

1.8

I'm gonna visit my cousin.

This reduction is normal educated speech, not slang — but only before a verb. "I'm going to London" never reduces. Recognising it matters more at A1 than producing it.

Module 8: Plans & Abilities · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Gonna, the can/can't Contrast & Negative Stress

Weak forms across a long text

I.10

was /wəz/, are /ə/, to /tə/, and /ən/

Small words shrink. A learner who expects every word at full strength hears English as impossibly fast; recognising weak forms is what makes normal speed become normal.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level I Consolidation — Endings, Weak Forms & Rhythm

Level II · Elementary Programme A2

used to -> /'ju:stə/

II.1

I used to work in an office.

The d disappears entirely and to reduces. Learners who listen for a clear "used TO" miss the structure completely, and with it the whole meaning of a past habit.

Module 1: Life Stories · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Used To, Weak Past Forms & Interrupted Actions

Announcement rhythm is slower and over-articulated

II.2

The sixTEEN FORTy service to MANchester

Public-address English is deliberately slowed and chunked. Practising at this pace first makes normal speed easier afterwards, not harder.

Module 2: Travel & Transport · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Teen and Ty, Announcement Rhythm & Checking Back

Do you -> /dʒə/ in questions

II.3

D'you need a uniform? What time d'you start?

This reduction is standard in ordinary speech. Recognising it is essential; learners often fail to notice a question has been asked at all.

Module 3: Work & Study · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Final Clusters, D'you Reduction & Instruction Stress

Hedges reduce almost to nothing

II.4

to be honest -> /təbi'ɒnɪst/; sort of -> /'sɔ:təv/

These softeners are unstressed and fast. Missing them means hearing a much stronger opinion than the speaker actually gave.

Module 4: Likes, Dislikes & Opinions · Pronunciation Lab 4 — The Melody of Disagreement, Hedges & Concession

I'll and shall we reduce heavily

11.5

I'll text you -> /aɪl/; Shall we -> /ʃəwi/

The future in speech is often just one extra consonant. Learners listening for a whole word will hear the present tense and misunderstand when something is happening.

Module 5: Making Plans · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Future Reductions, Arrangement Stress & Suggesting

than reduces to /ðən/ or even /ðn/

11.6

bigger than that -> /'bɪɡəðn ðæt/

In comparisons than nearly disappears. It is grammatically essential and phonetically almost absent — a combination that makes comparatives hard to hear.

Module 6: Homes & Neighbourhoods · Pronunciation Lab 6 — The Schwa, Weak Than & Comparative Stress

cut down, cut out: the phrasal verb stresses the particle

11.7

cut DOWN gradually; cut it OUT completely

English phrasal verbs put the stress on the small word. This is counter-intuitive and is why learners often mishear which advice was given.

Module 7: Food, Health & Habits · Pronunciation Lab 7 — The /v/ Sound, Frequency Stress & Phrasal-Verb Stress

would you -> /wʊdʒə/; I'd rather -> /aɪd'ra:ðə/

11.8

Would you like a refund? I'd rather have the refund.

Offers and preferences are among the most reduced structures in English. Hearing them accurately is what lets you respond to what was actually offered.

Module 8: Shopping & Services · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Polite Firmness, Offer Reductions & Contrastive Stress

Discourse markers are fast and unstressed

11.9

So, / Anyway, / And then, / Well,

These organise the story but carry little meaning, so they are said quickly. Learners who treat them as content words fall behind immediately.

Module 9: Telling Stories · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Narrative Pace, Discourse Markers & Backgrounding

Weak forms across a long text

II.10

have /əv/, was /wəz/, than /ðən/, to /tə/, and /ən/

Level II ends where it began: small words shrink. Once you can hear them reliably, natural-speed English stops sounding fast and starts sounding normal.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level II Consolidation — Weak Forms, Numbers & Conversational Melody

Level III · Intermediate Programme B1

have, has and 've almost disappear

III.1

I've worked -> /aɪv'wɜ:kt/; has been -> /əzbiːn/

The auxiliary is unstressed and often reduced to a single consonant. This is why learners hear "I worked" when the speaker said "I've worked" — and lose the distinction the whole module teaches.

Module 1: Present Perfect & Life Experience · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Reduced Auxiliaries, Strong Forms & Experience Questions

Signposting phrases are fast and formulaic

III.2

which brings me to -> /wɪtʃ'brɪŋzmiːtə/

These phrases carry structure, not content, so they are compressed. Learn them as single units rather than word by word.

Module 2: Education & Learning · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Section Resets, Signposting Chunks & Contrast Stress

Hedges compress to near nothing

III.3

I suppose -> /aɪspəʊz/; sort of -> /sɔ:təv/; I'd want -> /aɪdwɒnt/

Professional English is dense with these. A learner who does not hear them receives a much blunter message than the speaker sent.

Module 3: Work, Careers & Entrepreneurship · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Hedged Criticism, Compressed Softeners & Limiters

That's a fair point compresses to a single unit

III.4

/ðætsə'feəpɔɪnt/

Formulaic concessions are said as one word. Treating them as four separate words costs you the following clause, which is where the actual argument is.

Module 4: Opinions & Debate · Pronunciation Lab 4 — Concede-and-Turn, Connector Pitch & Formulaic Concessions

rose from X to Y links across the numbers

III.5

from thirty-one to thirty-eight -> /frəm,θɜ:ti'wʌntə,θɜ:ti'eɪt/

The prepositions vanish between the figures. Learners often hear two unconnected numbers and miss which direction the change went.

Module 5: Environment, Ethics & Global Citizenship · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Figures in Speech, Fact-versus-Judgement Pitch & Linking Numbers

more likely to report compresses heavily

III.6

/mɔ: 'laɪklɪtəri'pɔ:t/

The careful qualifiers of research language are exactly the parts that compress in speech, which is part of why they are so easily lost.

Module 6: Technology & Media · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Contrastive Stress, Headline Register & Vanishing Qualifiers

Minimisers compress and cluster

III.8

it's just that -> /ɪts'dʒʌstðæt/; a bit -> /ə'bit/

English wraps criticism in small fast words. Learners who hear only the stressed content receive the complaint without its softening — and often overreact.

Module 8: Travel & Culture · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Hinted Complaint, Minimisers & Pronoun Stress in Repair

Academic register still reduces

III.9

that doesn't -> /ðæt'dʌznt/; can't you -> /kɑ:ntfə/

Formality does not stop reduction. Expecting careful full forms in academic speech is why lectures feel faster than seminars, when both are equally reduced.

Module 9: Academic Foundations · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Rule-versus-Reason Stress, Academic Reduction & Conditional Shape

Auxiliaries and hedges together at full speed

III.10

they've /ðeɪv/, I suspect /aɪsə'spekt/, it might be /ɪt'maɪtbi/

Level III closes on its central listening problem: the words carrying grammar and certainty are the least audible ones. Hearing them is the level's real achievement.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level III Consolidation — Auxiliaries, Hedges & Panel Rhythm

Level IV · Upper Intermediate Programme B2

had reduces to /əd/ or vanishes into 'd

IV.1

they'd been managed; what had happened -> /wɒtəd'hæpənd/; I'd been solving

The past perfect is carried by a sound barely present. Learners hear a past simple and lose the entire time relationship the speaker is building.

Module 1: Advanced Present & Past Systems · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Reduced had, Hindsight Contour & Paired Abstractions

Academic hedges cluster before the point

IV.2

nobody would disagree -> /'nɒsbədiwəd,dɪsə'gri:/

Even direct academic criticism arrives wrapped in fast unstressed hedging. Hearing the wrapper is what keeps the criticism proportionate.

Module 2: Academic Writing I · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Diagnostic Contrast, Socratic Rise & Clustered Hedges

Modal + have compresses in reflection

IV.3

I should have flagged it -> /aɪʃədəv'flæɡdɪt/; I'd rather -> /aɪd'ra:ðə/

Self-correction and preference structures are heavily reduced. Hearing them accurately is what lets you tell an admission from a deflection.

Module 3: The World of Work · Pronunciation Lab 3 — Observation-versus-Evaluation Stress, Consent Rise & Reflective Reduction

Passives compress heavily

IV.5

was suspended -> /wəz sə'spendɪd/; *had been translated* -> /əd bɪn'trænzleɪtɪd/

Institutional English is dense with passives, and the auxiliaries carrying them are unstressed. Missing them costs you who did what, and whether it has already happened.

Module 5: Science, Technology & Ethics · Pronunciation Lab 5 — Compressed Passives, Organising Contrasts & Concede-then-Conclude

Agreement formulas compress fully

IV.6

I'd agree with that -> /aɪd ə'gri:wɪðæt/

In fast professional disagreement, the agreements are the most compressed parts. Missing them makes a nuanced exchange sound like a row.

Module 6: Global Issues · Pronunciation Lab 6 — Refusing a False Choice, Subordinated Figures & Compressed Agreement

Reported speech compresses around the verb

IV.7

she said that -> /ʃi'sedðæt/; *would have been* -> /wəd əv bɪn/

The reporting frame is fast and unstressed while the reported content is clear. That asymmetry is how you separate attribution from assertion in real time.

Module 7: Media Literacy & Critical Reading · Pronunciation Lab 7 — Fact-versus-Inference Stress, Unhedged Register & Reporting Frames

Negotiation formulas compress

IV.8

we can't do -> /wi'ka:ntdu/; *I can take that to* -> /aɪkən'teɪkðætə/

At full professional speed the framing compresses and only the numbers stay clear. That is deliberate: the figures are what must not be misheard.

Module 8: Meetings & Negotiation · Pronunciation Lab 8 — Conditional Stress, Probe-versus-Offer Contours & Numeric Clarity

Whose and who's are indistinguishable in speech

IV.9

whose paragraph it is -> /hu:z'pærəgrɑ:fɪtɪz/

Context alone disambiguates. At B2 this is worth noticing consciously, because academic English uses both constantly and the ear must rely on syntax rather than sound.

Module 9: Academic Writing II · Pronunciation Lab 9 — Abstract-Noun Contrast, Instruction Contour & Homophone Disambiguation

Full professional speed with everything reduced

IV.10

that hasn't been done -> /ðæt'hæzntbm'dʌn/; I'd still argue -> /aɪd'stɪl'a:gju:/

Level IV closes at the pace of a real meeting. Every feature from the level appears at once, and none of it is slowed for the listener.

Module 10: Review & Consolidation · Pronunciation Lab 10 — Level IV Consolidation — Meeting Pace, Verdict Stress & Closure

Level V · Advanced Programme C1

Distancing formulas compress

V.1

I'd never tell you to -> /aɪd'nevətɛljʊtə/; I'd simply observe -> /aɪd'sɪmpliəb'zɜ:v/

These constructions let a speaker advise without advising. They are fast, formulaic, and their compression is precisely what makes them deniable.

Module 1: Nuance & Idiom · Pronunciation Lab 1 — Implicature by Intonation, Evaluative Contrast & Deniable Advice

Page and chapter references stay clear while framing compresses

V.2

I set those out on page one hundred and four -> framing fast, NUMBER clear

As in negotiation, the citable facts resist compression. Speakers protect the parts a listener must be able to check.

Module 2: Academic Writing III · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Concede-then-Defend, Modal Boundary Stress & Protected References

Level VI · English Mastery Programme C2

Impersonal formulas compress into single units

VI.2

would find it difficult to -> /wəd'faɪndɪt'dɪfɪkəltə/; may I suggest -> /meɪaɪsə'dʒest/

These constructions remove the person from the objection. They are formulaic and fast, and hearing them as units rather than words is essential at this speed.

Module 2: Diplomacy & International Relations · Pronunciation Lab 2 — Litotes Delivery, Degree Adverbs & Impersonal Formulas

The model scripts

One model per module, written for the audio programme. The recordings have not been produced: 60 scripts exist and no audio file does. They are printed here because a teacher can read a model aloud, and a script nobody can see is a script nobody can use.

Level I

Meeting People

1.1

Hello.
How are you?
I'm from Japan.
I'm from China.
Where are you from?

BrE - 80 words per minute

Everyday Objects & Places

1.2

There is a book on the table.
There are two chairs.
This is my pen.
That is the door.

BrE - 77 words per minute

Family & Routines

1.3

He works in a bank.
She leaves at seven.
She watches television.
I get up at six.

BrE - 80 words per minute

Food & Shopping

1.4

I'd like some apples.

Is there any bread?

How much is that?

That's four pounds fifty.

BrE - 80 words per minute

Around Town

1.5

Excuse me.

Go straight on.

Turn right.

It's next to the bank.

BrE - 83 words per minute

Describing People & Things

1.6

It's a small black bag.

She has long brown hair.

He's tall and young.

That's mine.

BrE - 83 words per minute

Past Experiences

1.7

I visited my grandmother.

We cooked together.

They played football.

It rained.

BrE - 85 words per minute

Plans & Abilities

I.8

I'm going to visit my cousin.

Can you play tennis?

No, I can't.

I can swim quite well.

BrE - 85 words per minute

Health & Feelings

I.9

I have a bad headache.

My throat hurts.

You should rest.

You shouldn't go to work.

BrE - 83 words per minute

Review & Consolidation

I.10

Classes start at nine o'clock.

They walked to the museum.

You should tell your teacher.

There is going to be a party.

BrE - 90 words per minute

Level II

Life Stories

II.1

I used to work in an office.

I was walking home.

While I was watching her...

That was eight years ago.

BrE - 90 words per minute

Travel & Transport

11.2

The sixteen forty service.
Platform thirteen.
I've missed my connection.
Is this ticket still valid?

BrE · 93 words per minute

Work & Study

11.3

I start at half past eight.
She knows the system.
Do I need a uniform?
Ask me if you have a problem.

BrE · 93 words per minute

Likes, Dislikes & Opinions

11.4

I'm not really keen on it.
I don't mind either way.
I see your point, but...
That sounds good to me.

BrE · 95 words per minute

Making Plans

11.5

I'm meeting my brother at eleven.
I'm going to visit the gallery.
Shall we meet at half past twelve?
I'll text you.

BrE · 95 words per minute

Homes & Neighbourhoods

11.6

It's bigger than the other one.

It's much brighter.

It's the most sensible choice.

There's a park nearby.

BrE · 95 words per minute

Food, Health & Habits

11.7

How often do you exercise?

Hardly ever.

Four or five cups a day.

You should cut down gradually.

BrE · 95 words per minute

Shopping & Services

11.8

It's stopped working.

Do you have the receipt?

I'd prefer a replacement.

I'd rather have the refund.

BrE · 97 words per minute

Telling Stories

11.9

This happened three years ago.

We were having dinner.

Suddenly the lights went out.

Everyone started laughing.

BrE · 97 words per minute

Review & Consolidation

II.10

I've been here for eight months.
I used to work in a bookshop.
It's bigger and busier than Seville.
We're leaving on the fifteenth of July.

BrE · 100 words per minute

Level III

Present Perfect & Life Experience

III.1

Have you done any volunteering before?
I've worked there for two years.
I haven't done it since.
What's been the most difficult part?

BrE · 105 words per minute

Education & Learning

III.2

I want to cover three things.
Moving on to my second point.
Which brings me to...
That is precisely the trap.

BrE · 110 words per minute

Work, Careers & Entrepreneurship

III.3

There's a lot here that works.
My only real concern is the pricing.
It feels slightly optimistic.
A stated assumption is stronger than a hidden one.

BrE · 107 words per minute

Opinions & Debate

III.4

The data is unambiguous.
I don't dispute the air quality.
That's a fair point, but...
Provided the exemptions are real.

BrE · 110 words per minute

Environment, Ethics & Global Citizenship

III.5

It rose from thirty-one to thirty-eight per cent.
It fell by about four per cent.
In our view, the fall is explained by...
That is an interpretation, not established fact.

BrE · 110 words per minute

Technology & Media

III.6

A new study suggests that...
People may be more likely to report low mood.
Scientists prove: lack of sleep causes depression.
Notice what happened to the hedges.

BrE · 110 words per minute

Health, Body & Mind

III.7

Everyone wakes briefly several times a night.
That must raise your alertness.
It can't be the whole story.
Turn the clock away.

BrE · 110 words per minute

Travel & Culture

III.8

Can I have a quick word?

It's just that we tend to eat at seven.

I didn't realise it mattered.

I should have explained.

BrE · 110 words per minute

Academic Foundations

III.9

Don't guess a source.

A wrong citation damages trust.

If you can't trace it, state it as your own reasoning.

Referencing is how a reader checks you.

BrE · 113 words per minute

Review & Consolidation

III.10

Attendance has risen by about twelve per cent.

I don't dispute the figure.

It might be the timetable change.

Keep the projects, halve the reading.

BrE · 115 words per minute

Level IV

Advanced Present & Past Systems

IV.1

They had already missed two deadlines.

What had actually happened was simpler.

I'd been solving the wrong problem.

Reasonable and right aren't the same thing.

BrE · 120 words per minute

Academic Writing I

IV.2

That's a topic, not a thesis.
Increases it for whom, and measured how?
That's arguable, which is the point.
A thesis someone could contest is a thesis.

BrE · 120 words per minute

The World of Work

IV.3

Is now all right?
I'm not assuming I know why.
The issue isn't your work rate, it's the handover.
Raising a dependency isn't blame.

BrE · 120 words per minute

Arguing a Position

IV.4

Most people attack the worst version.
The strong version is much harder to answer.
State your opponent's case better than they can.
Then you've actually won something.

BrE · 123 words per minute

Science, Technology & Ethics

IV.5

The trial was suspended in March.
The first objection was procedural.
A large incentive undermines voluntariness.
It can't be resolved by better paperwork.

BrE · 123 words per minute

Global Issues

IV.6

It's right on that measure.
A relative measure shows almost no change.
They measure different things.
It isn't wrong, it's partial.

BrE · 123 words per minute

Media Literacy & Critical Reading

IV.7

Who told you the minister knew?
Both said it independently.
Those aren't the same claim.
It's a story we can stand up.

BrE · 123 words per minute

Meetings & Negotiation

IV.8

Our position is that the rate has to rise.
What's driving your ceiling?
If you'll extend the term, yes.
I can take that to my board.

BrE · 125 words per minute

Academic Writing II

IV.9

Your chapter reads as eight summaries.
Coverage isn't the problem, organisation is.
Organise by argument, not by author.
When a reader can't tell whose paragraph it is, you're synthesising.

BrE · 125 words per minute

Review & Consolidation

IV.10

The evidence is that they outperform by a clear margin.
That comparison is confounded.
Accepted, but I can't show how much from this data.
Then that's the recommendation.

BrE - 127 words per minute

Level V

Nuance & Idiom

V.1

They'll give it a very thorough hearing.
The paper is good. The timing is dreadful.
I'd never tell you to wait.
April is a much more forgiving month.

BrE - 130 words per minute

Academic Writing III

V.2

Why should we generalise from it?
We shouldn't, and I don't.
That's the strongest objection to the thesis.
Narrows, but does not close.

BrE - 130 words per minute

Leadership & Persuasion

V.3

I'll give you the decision first.
This was my recommendation.
That's a fair point and it's partly true.
It doesn't change the arithmetic now.

BrE - 130 words per minute

Complex Systems (Science, Economics, Policy)

V.4

The forecast was out by about forty per cent.
The inputs were within about five per cent.
It's not a calibration problem.
I'd want to test it before committing in writing.

BrE · 133 words per minute

Cross-Cultural Communication

V.5

Nobody pushed back at all.
They pushed back three times.
That was a stronger no.
He was waiting to be asked.

BrE · 130 words per minute

Advanced Media & Discourse Analysis

V.6

Will you resign if the report criticises you?
What matters to the public is that it's published.
I was warned eleven months ago.
Notice it contains no information at all.

BrE · 133 words per minute

Research & Presentation

V.7

One argument today, in three steps.
The limitation, before anyone asks, is...
I haven't. I'll read it this week.
That's outside what my data can support.

BrE · 133 words per minute

Professional Advocacy

V.8

Here is what we know.

Here is what we do not yet know.

You will hear from us at four o'clock.

I'm not going to speculate about a document I haven't seen.

BrE - 133 words per minute

Style & Voice

V.9

The implementation resulted in a reduction in participation.

When we introduced the policy, fewer young people applied.

Nominalisation hides agents.

Who did what to whom?

BrE - 133 words per minute

Review & Consolidation

V.10

I'd want to understand the assumption.

That would be unusually fast.

I'm opposed to approving it on this arithmetic.

Approve market one, defer market two.

BrE - 135 words per minute

Level VI

Mastery Diagnostic & Executive Leadership

VI.1

I'd recommend that the committee approve it.

It's essential that the staff hear this from you.

The decision was mine.

I'd own the consequence.

BrE - 140 words per minute

Diplomacy & International Relations

VI.2

My delegation would find it difficult to accept.
It would not be unhelpful to know which part.
We are not in a position to commit.
What does each of us need the paragraph to achieve?

BrE · 137 words per minute

Global Business Strategy

VI.3

Volume is down eleven per cent.
My inference is that we are losing volume to price.
What would have to be true for that to be wrong?
Indicative, not conclusive.

BrE · 140 words per minute

Public Policy

VI.4

The authority may require an inspection.
May confers discretion.
Assessed against enforceability, the second is weakest.
It should go to ministers as such.

BrE · 137 words per minute

Law & Justice

VI.5

Subject to section nine, this clause applies.
Notwithstanding section nine, this clause applies.
The best case for the defendant is...
Not with the premise but with the scope.

BrE · 137 words per minute

Innovation & Emerging Technologies

VI.6

Were this approach to work...
Should it not work, we will have learned something.
Had they raised prices, this proposal would not exist.
What would have to be true for the timeline to hold?

BrE · 140 words per minute

Media & Public Communication

VI.7

Let me correct the premise.
That's the part I'd defend least.
On reaching customers, yes. On acting, no.
I've asked for it to be published unedited.

BrE · 140 words per minute

Research & Scholarship

VI.8

The intervention demonstrates improved retention.
The correct verb is 'is consistent with'.
They feel like better writing and they are worse scholarship.
Aldridge is more equivocal than that.

BrE · 140 words per minute

Ethics & Responsible Leadership

VI.9

Even though the forms permit it...
Even if publication caused no harm...
I'm arguing from consequences. You're arguing from an obligation.
However strong the research case...

BrE · 140 words per minute

Capstone — Global Challenges & Mastery Examination

VI.10

Defend the premise, not the conclusion.

That's the weakest link.

That's outside what my evidence covers.

I could. It wouldn't have been true.

BrE · 143 words per minute

The curriculum order

The same targets in the order the programme teaches them, for planning a term rather than solving a problem in class. Classroom stage times are the curriculum's own designed minutes.

Level I

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
I.1 Meeting People	3	Individual sounds, Word stress, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
I.2 Everyday Objects & Places	3	Individual sounds, Connected speech, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
I.3 Family & Routines	3	Individual sounds, Connected speech, Word stress	2 lessons · 10 min
I.4 Food & Shopping	3	Individual sounds, Word stress, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
I.5 Around Town	3	Individual sounds, Rhythm, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
I.6 Describing People & Things	3	Individual sounds, Word stress, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
I.7 Past Experiences	3	Individual sounds, Connected speech, Rhythm	2 lessons · 10 min
I.8 Plans & Abilities	3	Connected speech, Individual sounds, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
I.9 Health & Feelings	3	Individual sounds, Intonation, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
I.10 Review & Consolidation	3	Individual sounds, Connected speech, Sentence stress	1 lesson · 5 min

Level II

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
II.1 Life Stories	3	Connected speech, Individual sounds, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
II.2 Travel & Transport	3	Word stress, Connected speech, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
II.3 Work & Study	3	Individual sounds, Connected speech, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
II.4 Likes, Dislikes & Opinions	3	Intonation, Connected speech, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
II.5 Making Plans	3	Connected speech, Sentence stress, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
II.6 Homes & Neighbourhoods	3	Individual sounds, Connected speech, Word stress	2 lessons · 10 min
II.7 Food, Health & Habits	3	Individual sounds, Sentence stress, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
II.8 Shopping & Services	3	Intonation, Connected speech, Word stress	2 lessons · 10 min
II.9 Telling Stories	3	Rhythm, Connected speech, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
II.10 Review & Consolidation	3	Connected speech, Word stress, Intonation	1 lesson · 5 min

Level III

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
III.1 Present Perfect & Life Experience	3	Connected speech, Sentence stress, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
III.2 Education & Learning	3	Intonation, Connected speech, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
III.3 Work, Careers & Entrepreneurship	3	Intonation, Connected speech, Word stress	2 lessons · 10 min

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
III.4 Opinions & Debate	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
III.5 Environment, Ethics & Global Citizenship	3	Word stress, Intonation, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
III.6 Technology & Media	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
III.7 Health, Body & Mind	3	Sentence stress, Individual sounds, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
III.8 Travel & Culture	3	Intonation, Connected speech, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
III.9 Academic Foundations	3	Sentence stress, Connected speech, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
III.10 Review & Consolidation	3	Connected speech, Sentence stress, Intonation	1 lesson · 5 min

Level IV

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
IV.1 Advanced Present & Past Systems	3	Connected speech, Intonation, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
IV.2 Academic Writing I	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
IV.3 The World of Work	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
IV.4 Arguing a Position	3	Intonation, Sentence stress, Rhythm	2 lessons · 10 min
IV.5 Science, Technology & Ethics	3	Connected speech, Sentence stress, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
IV.6 Global Issues	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
IV.7 Media Literacy & Critical Reading	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
IV.8 Meetings & Negotiation	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
IV.9 Academic Writing II	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
IV.10 Review & Consolidation	3	Connected speech, Sentence stress, Intonation	1 lesson · 5 min

Level V

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
V.1 Nuance & Idiom	3	Intonation, Sentence stress, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
V.2 Academic Writing III	3	Intonation, Sentence stress, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
V.3 Leadership & Persuasion	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Rhythm	2 lessons · 10 min
V.4 Complex Systems (Science, Economics, Policy)	3	Word stress, Sentence stress, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
V.5 Cross-Cultural Communication	3	Rhythm, Intonation, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
V.6 Advanced Media & Discourse Analysis	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Word stress	2 lessons · 10 min
V.7 Research & Presentation	3	Rhythm, Intonation, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
V.8 Professional Advocacy	3	Rhythm, Intonation, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
V.9 Style & Voice	3	Rhythm, Sentence stress, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
V.10 Review & Consolidation	3	Intonation, Sentence stress, Rhythm	1 lesson · 5 min

Level VI

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
VI.1 Mastery Diagnostic & Executive Leadership	3	Word stress, Sentence stress, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
VI.2 Diplomacy & International Relations	3	Intonation, Sentence stress, Connected speech	2 lessons · 10 min
VI.3 Global Business Strategy	3	Rhythm, Sentence stress, Word stress	2 lessons · 10 min
VI.4 Public Policy	3	Word stress, Rhythm, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min
VI.5 Law & Justice	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Word stress	2 lessons · 10 min
VI.6 Innovation & Emerging Technologies	3	Word stress, Intonation, Rhythm	2 lessons · 10 min
VI.7 Media & Public Communication	3	Intonation, Sentence stress, Rhythm	2 lessons · 10 min
VI.8 Research & Scholarship	3	Word stress, Sentence stress, Intonation	2 lessons · 10 min
VI.9 Ethics & Responsible Leadership	3	Word stress, Intonation, Sentence stress	2 lessons · 10 min

MODULE	TARGETS	FOCUS	CLASSROOM STAGE
VI.10 Capstone — Global Challenges & Mastery Examination	3	Sentence stress, Intonation, Rhythm	1 lesson · 6 min

This publication in the WEC Press record

Every publication of the Press carries this apparatus, generated from one source, so that a reader in twenty years can identify this copy, cite it, catalogue it, and find the publications it belongs beside — without needing anyone who made it.

Place in the ecosystem

Issue	E01.R00.01 — edition 01, revision 00, impression 01
Family	IEFC Reference Library
What the family is for	Consulted rather than read through: grammar, vocabulary, pronunciation, listening scripts, glossary, cross-references.
Maturity	First edition
What that means	One edition issued. It has not been reviewed by anyone other than its makers, and a reader should weigh it accordingly.

Published beside this volume

- The IEFC Listening Scripts
- A Grammar of the IEFC
- A Glossary of the IEFC
- The IEFC Companion

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2026-08-21	Correct a false institutional identity: this is Worldwide English College
2026-08-17	Rebrand the institution to Albalagh International Premium College
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